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CLIMATE



**Mission Barns is betting
that animal-free pork fat
will make artificial meat
delicious**



Tim De Chant — 4:00 AM PDT · July 24, 2025

An old colleague always had a curious request at lunchtime. For health reasons, he was vegetarian, but he still missed the taste of ground beef. So he'd ask the chef in the cafeteria for a veggie burger that was cooked next to the beef patties. The grease that seeped over made the plant substitute taste that much better.

The folks at [Mission Barns](#) must have overheard our lunchtime conversation. They have developed animal-free, cultured pork fat. The product just received approval from the U.S. Department of Agriculture, the company exclusively told [TechCrunch](#). The stamp of approval allows the startup to sell the fat to consumers.

It's the first such product to reach the market, and it could unlock a host of fattened-up meat alternatives.

"It really enables anyone, any of our partners who are using our ingredient, to also launch a product into market," Cecilia Chang, chief business officer at Mission Barns, told [TechCrunch](#).

Scientists have been trying to culture meat for years. The world's first lab-grown burger hit food critics' mouths [in 2013](#), though it cost an estimated \$330,000. The costs have come down significantly since then, but a burger made from lab-grown beef still costs [several times that of a McDonald's classic](#). Part of the problem is that muscle cells

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require something to grow on, whereas most cells cultured today grow in large vats of liquid media.

But fat isn't as picky, making it easier to grow at a cost that consumers can swallow. And when it comes to flavor, it packs a punch.

To grow the fat, Mission Barns first takes a small sample, like a biopsy, from a living pig. It then introduces it into a bioreactor containing a growth media. Because fat floats, the startup had to develop its own bioreactor to ensure the cells were evenly distributed throughout the media. If they clumped at the top, they wouldn't get access to enough food to grow properly.

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Mission Barns' first products are bacon, meatball, and sausage alternatives made using pea protein paired with its cultured pork fat. The startup is also supplying other companies with its fat to incorporate into their own recipes. In the long run, Chang said, selling to other food manufacturers will be its main business.

Pea protein is a common ingredient among alternative meats, but Chang said that Mission Barns’ recipe differs. “Because the fat gives you so much flavor, you’re actually taking out some of the most expensive ingredients in an alternative protein product, the artificial flavorings,” she said.

Chang also said that, perhaps incongruously, Mission Barns’ cultured pork fat should allow for healthier alternative meats. Recipes won’t need as much salt to mask the pea protein taste, and the company can tweak what the cells eat, boosting omega-3 fats, for example.

For future products, Mission Barns is mulling pork fat with a more intense flavor. “You can get away with adding less of the fat, and that has the nutritional profile of a salmon fat,” Chang said. “When we talk to partners, they’re like, ‘Oh hell yeah, sign me up.’”

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Tim De Chant is a senior climate reporter at TechCrunch. He has written for a wide range of publications, including...

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Brazil's Future Farm rakes in \$58M to sell more plant-based meat and dairy

Natasha Lomas — 5:10 AM PDT · November 3, 2021

Another big raise in the alternative protein space: [Future Farm](#), a Brazilian-based food tech startup that touts plant-based meat substitutes with a “true” meat-like texture, has closed a \$58 million

Series C funding round, co-led by DTC, as it gears up

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Farm's range of plant-based meat substitutes into more retail outlets and human mouths.

It is also planning to grow its range to add plant-based milks and "dairy" (including a butter alternative), to try to cut itself a larger slice of consumers' shopping budgets.

Future Farm's current product range — which is pretty self-explanatory in branding terms, featuring the likes of "Future Mince", "Future Burger" and "Future Sausage" — is available in 24 countries via 10,000 points of sale, but the LatAm startup is keen to step that up.

It launched products into the U.K. market at the start of last year — and touts strong growth in Europe, where it says its annual growth rate is 960%.

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Overall, it flags that the plant-based meat replacement category is now being valued at \$4.2 billion globally. While, in the U.K, alone, the market is said to be worth \$0.8 billion — and growing 17% a year.

Global attention on the climate crisis (the [CO26 climate conference](#) is taking place in the U.K. right now) — and on the need for humanity to cut carbon emissions by taking actions like slashing meat consumption — is feeding demand for plant-based alternatives to traditional meat-based meals like hamburgers, bolognese and hot dogs.

Investors have responded to this pressure to change eating habits by feeding dollars to a wave of food tech startups that promise to help meat-eaters effortlessly switch to a better-for-the-planet vegan lifestyle — “meatballs” and all (i.e. just without the actual meat bit).

The alternative protein space has thus become a hotbed of activity in recent years (although it’s worth noting that plant-based meat alternatives are nothing new, and products selling prepackaged veggie burgers etc. date back decades; what’s new is pressure on consumers to switch and investor interest in the category), with food tech startups like [Beyond Meat](#), [Impossible Foods](#), [Meati](#), [Fable Food](#), [Planted](#) and [Heura](#) mushrooming forth, to name a few.

There are also a growing number of lab-grown meat startups trying to keep actual meat on the menu but change its environmental profile by culturing cells in vats as an alternative production process to the intensive farming of animals which is both terrible for the planet and horrible for animal welfare.

Whatever happens with lab-grown meat, the future of food will certainly need to involve everyone eating a lot more plants.

[Allplants scoops \\$52M to deliver more plant-based microwave meals](#)

[Startups making meat alternatives are gaining traction worldwide](#)

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Plant-based food startup Next Gen lands \$10M seed round from investors including Temasek

Catherine Shu — 4:30 PM PST · February 24, 2021

Singapore is [quickly turning into a hub for food-tech startups](#), partly because of government initiatives supporting the development of meat alternatives. One of the newest entrants is [Next Gen](#), which will launch its plant-based “chicken” brand, called

[TiNDLE](#), in Singaporean restaurants next month. The company announced today that it has raised \$10 million in seed funding from investors including Temasek, K3 Ventures, EDB New Ventures (an investment arm of the Singapore Economic Development Board), NX-Food, FEBE Ventures and Blue Horizon.

Next Gen claims this is the largest seed round ever raised by a plant-based food tech company, based on data from PitchBook. This is the first time the startup has taken external investment, and the funding exceeded its original target of \$7 million. Next Gen was launched last October by Timo Recker and Andre Menezes, with \$2.2 million of founder capital.

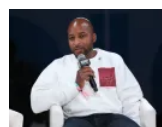
Next Gen’s first product is called TiNDLE Thy, an alternative to chicken thighs. Its ingredients include

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water, soy, wheat, oat fiber, coconut oil and methylcellulose, a culinary binder, but the key to its chicken-like flavor is a proprietary blend of plant-based fats, like sunflower oil, and natural flavors that allows it to cook like chicken meat.

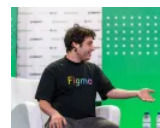
Menezes, Next Gen's chief operating officer, told TechCrunch that the company's goal is to be the global leader in plant-based chicken, the way Impossible and Beyond are known for their burgers.

"Consumers and chefs want texture in chicken, the taste and aroma, and that is largely related to chicken fat, which is why we started with thighs instead of breasts," said Menezes. "We created a chicken fat made from a blend, called Lipi, to emulate the smell, aroma and browning when you cook."

Both Recker and Menezes have years of experience in the food industry. Recker founded German-based LikeMeat, a plant-based meat producer acquired by the LIVEKINDLY Collective last year. Menezes' food career started in Brazil at one of the world's largest poultry exporters. He began working with plant-based meat after serving as general manager of Country Foods, a Singaporean importer and distributor that focuses on innovative, sustainable products.

"It was clear to me after I was inside the meat industry for so long that it was not going to be a sustainable business in the long run," Menezes said.

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Over the past few years, more consumers have started to feel the same way, and began looking for alternatives to animal products. UBS expects the global plant-based protein market to increase at a compounded annual growth rate of more than 30%, reaching about \$50 billion by 2025, as more people, even those who aren't vegans or vegetarians, seek healthier, humane sources of protein.

Startups making meat alternatives are gaining traction worldwide



Startups that produce lab-grown meat and meat substitutes are gaining traction and raising cash in global markets, mirroring a surge of support food tech

companies are seeing in the United States. New partnerships with global chains like McDonald's in Hong Kong, the launch of test kitchens in Israel and new financing rounds for startups in ... Continue reading

Millennial and Gen Z consumers, in particular, are willing to reduce their consumption of meat, eggs and dairy products as they become more aware of the environmental impact of industrial livestock production, said Menezes. “They understand the sustainability angle of it, and the health aspect, like the cholesterol or nutritional values, depending on what product you are talking about.”

Low in sodium and saturated fat, TiNDLE Thy has received the Healthier Choice Symbol, which is administered by Singapore’s Health Promotion Board. Next Gen’s new funding will be used to launch TiNDLE Thy, starting in popular Singaporean restaurants like Three Buns Quayside, the Prive Group, 28 HongKong Street, Bayswater Kitchen and The Goodburger.

Over the next year or two, Next Gen plans to raise its Series A round, launch more brands and products, and expand in its target markets: the United States (where it is currently recruiting a growth director to build a distribution network), China, Brazil and Europe. After working with restaurant partners, Next Gen also plans to make its products available to home cooks.

“The reason we started with chefs is because they are very hard to crack, and if chefs are happy with the product, then we’re very sure customers will be, too,” said Menezes.

Beyond Burger arrives in Alibaba’s grocery stores in China



Beyond Meat is starting to hit supermarket shelves in China after it first entered the country in April by supplying Starbucks’ plant-based menu. Within weeks, it had also forayed into select KFC, Taco Bell and Pizza Hut outlets — all under the Yum China empire. China, the world’s biggest market for meat consumption, has seen ...

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